

Home PCs

Home PCs keep seeing drastic changes. With every New Year we see more and more powerful PCs. In a few years, more powerful workstations might be available for regular users at a good price.

The upgradation path becomes more and more difficult though, as newer processors will require newer motherboards and different hardware to run.

The segment may shift from single-processor powered PCs to multi-core processors, and perhaps two graphic cards working simultaneously. Input devices will get cordless, with various options such as RF and Bluetooth.

The Home PC will soon work as a media centre, capable of playing radio (FM and Internet) as well as DVDs and VCDs without booting up the system.

Facts

❑ Cool systems perform better

that a system which is hot. Also, there is a risk of damage to the hardware when the system becomes hot; therefore, the cabinet must have good ventilation and an extra fan if possible.

❑ The cheapest way to increase the system performance is by increasing the system memory to around 512 MB. This will help in multitasking and with memory-intensive programs such as image-editing software and games.

❑ Also, use external add-ons in place of the on-board chipsets. An add-on video card can greatly enhance the system's performance in graphics-related activities.

❑ A faster hard disk improves the performance during video encoding and transfer of data; go for a 7,200 rpm or 10,000 rpm hard disk if you work with video editing and capturing software.

❑ Look for PC's that provide you with more connectivity options such as USB2.0 and Firewire. This



Buying Tips

✓ Make a list of the components you want to buy, such as the sound card, graphics card, hard disk, RAM, and last but not least, the processor. Assess your requirement thoroughly before making a choice.

✓ For a music enthusiast, a PC with a good sound card and speakers is important; similarly, for persons involved in video recording, storage performance and space is critical; for a gamer it's the graphics accelerator, RAM, and processor that matters the most.

✓ While buying a PC, always buy genuine parts; check for manufacturers' seals on the boxes before opening them, and enquire about possible future upgrades such as a BIOS upgrade for the board and so on.

✓ Buy a motherboard with onboard AGP and an AGP slot for expansion; opt for a motherboard that supports DDR2 memory. At this point, PCI-Express based chipsets can safely be overlooked in the interests of economy.

✓ A combo drive is adequate for most purposes, but a DVD-Writer is preferred as they can read and write both CDs and DVDs.

✓ For today's applications, 256 MB of RAM is a must. If you want to play the latest games as well, 512 MB would be a better choice.

✓ For normal work, buy an 80 GB hard disk to give you adequate room to hold music and videos in addition to your work-related software and data.

Ready Reckoner



You Need

A decent-performance system

Look for

A PC powered by a processor with speed in excess of 1.4 GHz with 256 MB of RAM and onboard AGP



You Need

A good multimedia PC for normal gaming

Look for

A PC powered by a processor with speed in excess of 1.8 GHz with 256 MB RAM and 64 MB AGP



You Need

A powerhouse PC for home entertainment and professional work

Look for

A PC powered by a processor with speed in excess of 2.4 GHz with 512 MB of RAM or more, and 128 MB AGP



will ensure that the Digicam sent to you on your birthday can be connected to your computer to save those videos on to a DVD.

❑ If your PC is your main source of entertainment such as gaming, watching movies and listening to music, make sure that you invest in the right peripherals even if it costs a bit more. A sound card such as the Audigy will only be a bit more expensive than the SoundBlaster Live, however, the performance it provides is excellent. Similarly, a Radeon 9600 will give you much better results in gaming than a run-of-the-mill Geforce4 MX 440. A Creative Inspire 5.1 will provide you with a much better aural experience than a cheap speaker set available from your PC dealer.

❑ Look for more add-on cards if you can fit it into your budget. A TV-Tuner card is a welcome addition since it will let you capture TV shows and you can watch them later at your own sweet time. If this increases the budget by about Rs 500, it still is a good deal.